(the line) between pain and pleasure

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(the line) between pain and pleasure

by sunandei

Summary

> “Do you understand the weight of your words?” Phainon asked him, his voice low and shaky.
>
> Mydei stared back at him, thumb stroking unruly, slightly wet from tears, hair strands away from Phainon’s temple. Depending on his answer, there would be no turning back.
>
> He had been deprived of affection and had fled it, taking refuge in violence. Now, he found out that he loved the thrill of being in Phainon’s arms as much as he loved the thrill of battle. Maybe, he would even learn to love it more.

Mydei almost dies again. As Hyacine is out of Okhema to assist at the Grove, a worried Phainon is left to tend to Mydei's wounds. A rare moment of intimacy, tenderness, and vulnerability between the two warriors during the flame-chase journey.

Notes

hello again!! new fic hehe

this is for the soft top phainon who finally allows himself to want and mydei who finally allows himself to be vulnerable agenda

canon settings! this takes place before tb's arrival on amphoreus

usual warning: english isn't my first language so, if you notice any grammar mistakes, no you did not. the english language is lying to you, wake up !!!

thank you to my friend for helping me bc i struggled with this one<3

See the end of the work for more notes

“- is immortal, Lord Phainon.” He finally discerned an intelligible sound above the constant buzzing in his ears; a girl’s soft voice. “He is going to be fine. You need to calm down first.”

“But his injuries are too severe! Titans, he’s losing so much blood and -” He could not make out the rest as a loud and strident noise resonated in his head, replacing the man’s distressed voice. The next thing he heard was metal clinking and clothes rustling - his own, he guessed - and he felt a warm hand stripping him from his chiton, the soft fabric sliding against his skin.

“... Mydei? Mydeimos? Are you still here?” He felt another hand on his cheek. The touch was oddly tender, holding him carefully as if he could possibly break.

He tried to answer but, in his current state, he could only let out a pitiful groan. He struggled to open his eyes. Vision clouded, he could only make out two silhouettes: one towering him as he laid on the cold floor, and the other keeping a safe distance from them. *Ah,* thought Mydei. *Phainon and Castorice.*

“His eyes are unfocused. He needs treatment right away, Castorice, we can’t wait for Hyacine to return!” Mydei winced at how loud Phainon sounded above him.

Treatment? Were they talking about him? Well … now that they mentioned it, Mydei did feel like his whole body was burning up, sweaty, and his head was throbbing. His legs were also starting to feel numb, and, worst of it all, was the sharp ache and inexplicable feeling of something missing in his stomach. But the warrior had always tolerated pain. Pain was much more familiar to him than the gentle hand stroking wet strands of hair away from his face.

“I can guide you, Lord Phainon. I have spent enough time with Hyacine to know the basics. We can save him if we stay calm. Can you do it?” Castorice’s soothing seemed to work on Phainon.

“Yeah, I can.” His voice was steadier. “Sorry. How do we proceed?”

“J-just,” Mydei managed to croak, “let me die. It will be quicker.”

He could not let them worry over him like this and burden them when neither had proper medical experience. He was not your typical patient to say the least; he was pretty sure his guts were spilling out right now. Moreover, as Castorice had said, he was going to be *fine*. His cursed body was disposable in times like this, after all.

He heard Phainon’s breath hitch. “Are you out of your mind, Mydei?! As if we would let you die in front of us!”

Mydei had wanted to retort that he was indeed out of his mind - delirium was a common side effect of blood loss - but the dizziness was getting to him again. He felt another pang in his stomach and grunted.

“We’re going to treat you. Castorice, where should we do this?”

Mydei had wanted to protest again. There was truly no need for them to go this far. It was not like he enjoyed dying either; he would prefer not to have to swim up the river of Souls, in all honesty. But he had long since then accepted that his body was a weapon. What most efficient way to obtain a brand new weapon than to throw away the broken one?

As strong arms lifted him, he knew it would not be long before he lost consciousness. The pain had swelled into white hot agony, but, oddly, the warmth from the firm chest he was pressed against helped to appease it.

His senses were filled with Phainon. He could hear the fast beating of the man's heart pulsating against his cheek and feel his ragged breath on him. He could smell the metallic tang of fresh blood mixed with Phainon's musky scent; it was a unique perfume he had grown familiar with during the constant battles of the flame-chase journey. He liked it. He tried to focus on it but felt himself slowly slipping into sleep, the buzzing in his ears growing dimmer until there was nothing but silence.

Mydei's condition stabilised only after a few hours; healing severe wounds was always less efficient than a quick death to regain a functional body. He drifted between states of light awareness and unconsciousness, his body heavy and his mind fuzzy.

He felt calloused hands deftly wrapping him in bandages, and a cold liquid dripping on his skin that made him hiss instinctively. He also heard footsteps coming in and out of the room, and the hushed voices of Phainon and Castorice while they discussed the prince's recovery. Mydei had tried to participate in the conversation - he was the main topic, it was only fair he had his say on it - but his voice had only echoed in his mind, his lips barely emitting any sound.

He felt sweaty and hot, his only relief being the wet towel gently wiping away beads of sweat on his face and dried blood. And, as those strong hands caressed his forehead again, he remembered words that were wistfully whispered to him:

"I wish you would treat yourself kinder, Mydeimos."

When Mydei woke up, he was feeling much better; his wounds had healed and closed on their own, leaving only sensitive scars on soft muscles. He brought a bare hand to his hair and grimaced slightly at the touch. He no longer had a headache, which was good, but he really needed a shower.

He got up to sit on the edge of the bed he was laying on, a low groan escaping his lips. He was used to the uncomfortable itch of wound scabs pulling at his body. He was a warrior. An immortal one, at that. He could take it. He had to.

He looked at his surroundings first: a familiar large bedroom, blue walls and sunlight shining through sheer white curtains. The sunrays reflected on yellow and purple antiques piled up in different corners of the room, blinding the blond as he squinted at them. Not Hyacine's infirmary, obviously; he recalled that she was out of Okhema for at least two weeks. He then looked down at himself.

Mydei didn't mind showing skin. His usual clothes certainly did not hide much of his chest and defined muscles - he dressed that way for both comfort and practicality. However, stripped of his pants, armor, gauntlets, chiton, and even his jewels, he felt oddly vulnerable. The thought that someone - more specifically, Phainon - had undressed him, leaving him only in a flimsy cloth that barely covered anything, made his face a bit warmer, a low heat spreading in his stomach.

He quickly put those thoughts away as he heard someone coming through the bedroom's door.

"Mydei," Phainon almost dropped the clean clothes he was holding, "You're awake!"

The white-haired man put the clothing aside on a desk and strode towards Mydei, coming to a halt just in front of him, one hand reaching for the blond's forehead. Mydei leaned a bit into the touch. Maybe his mind was still fuzzy.

"Are you feeling better?" Phainon asked, worry still lingering in his voice.

"Hm." was Mydei's only response.

Phainon narrowed his eyes and looked at his patient up and down, down and up. Once he seemed to be certain Mydei was fine, he pulled away and took a glass that was already filled with water from the nightstand.

"Here, you should drink. You slept quite a lot." He brought the glass to Mydei's lips.

Mydei took the glass with one hand and drank it whole, feeling suddenly very thirsty at the mention of water. He felt the liquid go down his throat and gulped a few times, Phainon's keen eyes watching him as he did so. Once Mydei had finished it, Phainon put the glass back on the nightstand.

"We need to change your bandages soon," he said with a concerned expression on his face. This prompted Mydei to look at his abdomen and he found light and brown blood stains on it. Truly nothing. "I just brought some from Hyacine's office, along with clean clothes for you. You should take a shower first, the bathroom is right -"

"Why are we in your room?" Mydei questioned him abruptly.

Phainon seemed to be taken aback. “I didn’t know how long it would take you to wake up … I didn’t want you to sleep on the small beds in the infirmary.” He answered a bit flustered.

Mydei hummed at that, his fingers skimming across the linen sheets of Phainon’s bed. He watched them slide easily on the soft fabric.

“It is indeed more comfortable here.” He agreed. He looked up again and was greeted by the sight of a blushing Phainon.

“Do you need help with showering?” Phainon blurted out.

Mydei immediately frowned. “No, I will manage.”

The deliverer looked so uncomfortable, Mydei wondered why he was even offering in the first place. He had already burdened him and Castorice enough, he could not ask more out of them. He needed to take a shower, dress (appropriately), and report to Aglaea about his last rescue mission.

“Right…” Phainon uttered in a tight voice.

He then turned around and disappeared in the joint bathroom, taking the clothes he had momentarily put aside with him. Mydei could catch the sound of water running as Phainon prepared a bath for him.

When Phainon came back into the room, Mydei took the time to observe him.

Phainon had also taken his coat off, leaving him only in that short-sleeved black shirt and choker he usually wore. He looked pretty normal, except for the slight tension in his shoulder that did not go unnoticed by Mydei. The blond just knew that Phainon wanted to say something, maybe even reprimand him. They had gone through this a lot of times: Phainon asking, no, *imploring*, the immortal to stop ‘recklessly’ discarding his lives and Mydei refusing to let his body know rest.

Mydei had never died in front of Phainon.

When they were together on a mission, they were unstoppable, two warriors of equal strength ravaging the battlefield. They always completed each other, covering the other’s weaknesses during offensive attacks; two puzzle pieces easily fitting together.

It was only on solo and more hazardous missions that Mydei had to resort to using his own life. After a few trips to Styxia and a target eliminated, he would come back to Okhema - more or less wrecked - and spend the day in Hyacine’s infirmary for treatment on her orders. Phainon would then always find him after succeeding in his own mission. Even when the deliverer decided not to comment on it, worried eyes would linger on Mydei, as if searching for hidden wounds. But there was never any; even scars faded with time.

Phainon had therefore never had to directly treat the immortal’s injuries until today.

Mydei knew Phainon was familiar with blood and death from a young age. On the rooftops of Okhema, in rare moments of intimacy and respite, they would sometimes confide in each

other, sharing tragic past stories. But flesh coming back together and skin slowly mending was truly a gruesome sight on its own. Repulsive. Mydei's hands unconsciously tightened around the bed's covers.

"I've put everything you might need in the bathroom. You can go, I'll wait here." Phainon told him as he stood next to the blond.

Mydei stared up at him but Phainon's gaze was avoidant. Mydei nodded nonetheless, "... Thank you."

He easily got up, feeling steady on his own two feet, a sign that his recovery was going well. He went to the bathroom without looking back even as he felt eyes following him.

Once Mydei was alone, he let out a small breath.

He should say something - or have Phainon spit out what he wanted to say - cause there was a palpable tension between them.

He unwrapped the bandages along his arms, trying to stop his thoughts from running back to the man sitting on the bed in the next room. He then worked on untying the bandages around his abdomen, tugging on them a bit, before they slid out easily and dropped to the marble floor.

Phainon's bathroom was neither small, nor spacious; just enough for a two-person bath decorated with gold edging and embedded in white tiles, a cabinet with towels and soaps against the opposite wall, and another one of Phainon's weird vases in a corner. Mydei also spotted the clean clothes in the cabinet: it was one of Phainon's trousers and a chiton of his that he had handed to Aglaea last week after one perilous mission. The woman's glassy eyes had twitched at the sight of his torn garment, and she had immediately requested for Mydei to give it to her so that she could stitch it back.

Mydei stepped into the bath and slowly sank into it until his back rested against the wall. He let out a long sigh, his muscles relaxing and softening even more. The water was at the right temperature; not too hot for his scars to sting, and not too cold to be unpleasant.

Mydei wasted no time, he soaked himself completely, then grabbed the soap and wash cloth Phainon had placed on the edge of the bath. He washed himself thoroughly, but was careful to not apply too much friction where his skin was the most sensitive. He repeated the same actions with the scented oil and a refreshing musky fragrance filled his senses. Sweet orange, peach blossom, and a note of cedarwood. The same scent - Phainon's scent - that had lulled him into unconsciousness just a few hours ago.

The chambers were silent, except for the echoing sound of droplets hitting the smooth surface of the water as they slipped down tan skin. Mydei tried to come up with something to say to appease a tensed Phainon.

He knew how to read the deliverer's emotions even through a breath. Expressing his own, on the other hand, had sometimes proved to be rather difficult.

Mydei was no liar - honesty was a Kremnoan's principle - and he never avoided confrontation. There were simply things he did not say; not the right time, not the right place, or, in some cases, not the right *feelings*. He kept them to himself but, unfortunately for him, just the presence of one white-haired man was enough to revive them, a low and burning heat in his stomach. A kind of pleasure that pained every time he felt those hands on him during their sparring sessions. But that is all they both allowed themselves: fleeting touches and lingering gazes.

Mydei sighed. He brushed a hand one last time through wet and heavy strands of hair before squeezing the water out them. He then got up and stepped out of the bath. He quickly dried himself and decided to only put on the trousers Phainon had prepared for him; he was sure the deliverer would not let him leave without bandaging his abdomen again. A useless thing, if you asked Mydei. Yet, he had the bad habit of indulging the man.

When he came back into the bedroom, Phainon was sitting on the bed, idly playing with a bottle of disinfectant. As he heard approaching footsteps, Phainon raised his head and locked eyes with Mydei before dropping his gaze to the paling scar on the warrior's stomach, his lips pressed in a tight line again. It must have looked nasty when it was fresh for Phainon to be this shaken up. But,right now, it was just another blemish on Mydei's body.

Still, Phainon beckoned the blond to sit next to him, already preparing a bandage. Mydei sighed silently before obeying, one knee on the bed and his other leg hanging off the edge. Phainon imitated him to face him properly, their knees barely touching, like a virtual wall between them.

"Deliverer," Mydei tried to call him but Phainon ignored him, choosing to unfold a cotton gauze roll instead of answering.

At first Mydei had wanted to apologize, and then, he had thought about thanking him. But he knew that this wasn't what Phainon wanted to hear. He just couldn't promise him what he wanted, so he opted for honesty to try to dispel the awkward atmosphere.

"There's no risk of it bleeding again. This is unnecessary, I can -"

"Taking care of you is not a burden, Mydeimos." Phainon cut him off, his voice clipped.

Obviously, this also was not what he had wanted to hear.

Mydei's lips parted but no sound came out of it.

Phainon was rarely mad. It was not a foreign emotion on the deliverer's face per say; Mydei had noticed the tension in his jaw when they would arrive in razed villages to fight black tide monsters, or the deep frown on his face when Aglaea had to invite members of the Council of Elders to their table. But it was never directed at Mydei.

Taken aback, the blond simply chose to shut his mouth and raise his arms as Phainon started to wrap the bandage around his abdomen, passing the roll from one hand to another behind Mydei's back.

Mydei inhaled sharply as he felt white hair strands and a warm breath tickling him, Phainon's face close, much too close, to his chest. A fire rekindled in him, his eyes never leaving Phainon as he studied his features.

Furrowed thin brows, slightly-crunched nose and pouty lips, the deliverer was wholly focused on his task. The obvious concern and hardly concealed exasperation made something flip in the prince's stomach. Entranced by the sight, he could not stop a small gasp of surprise - and of something else he did not want to acknowledge right now - from escaping his lips as he felt rough fingertips brushing against his skin.

The noise immediately alarmed Phainon who looked up, worried cerulean eyes staring straight into amber ones.

"Does it still hurt?" Phainon asked, fingers anxiously hovering over Mydei's sensitive skin.

The blond's pupils widened before averting his eyes, feeling his cheeks suddenly heat up, the burning sensation in his stomach even more intense with Phainon's attention on him. He was keenly aware of those fingertips almost touching him where he had always wanted, and that acute gaze searching for an answer on his face. He was freezing like prey under a predator's watch.

Mydei raised a fist to his mouth, a poor attempt at hiding the faint flush on his face.

"No -" He sounded much too affected by just a mere brush. He cleared his voice and repeated, "No, it doesn't hurt."

Phainon simply hummed, eyes never leaving Mydei's face, and Mydei felt as though he was being taken apart.

"Is it still sensitive, then? Or is it because you're ticklish?"

Phainon let his fingers skim along the edge of the bandage - his other hand still holding firmly one end of the roll to secure it around the prince's abdomen - and Mydel held back a hiss every time those fingertips grazed his skin, his muscles contracting unwarranted.

"You know … Hyacine told me you get much chattier while getting treatment, so why are you oddly quiet with me?"

Mydei frowned at the tease. He looked down at Phainon again. "Were you not mad at me two minutes earlier?"

Phainon chuckled and shook his head in disapproval, "I wouldn't say mad at *you*." He sighed before adding in a more serious tone, "You already know what I'm mad at."

Of course, Mydei knew. He inhaled deeply. "And I already told you that I couldn't promise you that."

He watched Phainon's eyes fill with sorrow at those words, before being replaced by resignation. The sight tugged at his heartstrings; maybe Phainon had grown tired of asking, of

imploring. Still, this was something only he, an immortal, could do. Fate had bestowed him with this curse, but he had forged it into a weapon of his own accord.

Phainon leaned into Mydei, resting his forehead on the red tattooed mark on the prince's sternum, and Mydei heard his heartbeat quicken, blood pumping loudly in his veins.

"I know, I just -" His warm breath tickled Mydei, sending a shiver up his spine.

"I just wish you wouldn't venture alone on these missions. If I'm here, then at least I could protect your physical self while your soul is wandering Styxia. We could talk to Aglaea about it." Phainon muttered, hiding his face more into Mydei's chest, as if well aware he was being unreasonable here.

Mydei's heart swelled at the display of vulnerability. The deliverer had never been bold to the point of involving Aglaea in his requests; he was a rational man after all.

Maybe it was the intimacy of the moment. Or, maybe, it was Mydei's innate restraint cracking under the weight of all those emotions he felt towards the man nuzzling against him. But he had almost agreed, had almost wanted to be unreasonable too. They could not afford it.

Mydei raised a hand to gently stroke white untamed hair, and Phainon leaned into his palm, his head instinctively following the motion like a grown puppy.

"Deliverer," Mydei admonished him jokingly, a small smile playing on his lips. "You, more than anyone else, understand what being part of the flame-chase entails and the sacrifices we made along our journey. Don't speak as if you don't have a brain."

Phainon did not feign a laugh in response, letting out an annoyed groan that resonated loudly in the back of his throat instead. But at least the soothing seemed to work and he relaxed in Mydei's hold.

Pressing closer to the blond's body and closing the distance that remained between them, he let go of the gauze he had been holding on, the bandage sliding off to reveal Mydei's navel, pristine skin, and the dips of his hips' bones.

Mydei felt a scorching heat everywhere their limbs were in contact and a sudden dizziness overcame him as Phainon's fingers explored his body, shamelessly tracing the curve of his waist, going past his ribs to his back, slowly rubbing up and down against the bumps of his spine. His hand tightened around white strands of hair, and he shivered once more when another hand settled on his waist, a thumb drawing circles on tan skin.

How strange. How pitiful. But also how exciting, thrilling. All it took was one man, with pathetic blue eyes and strong arms capable of lifting him, to render a formidable warrior like himself weak. Mydei was deeply convinced that, someday, that same man would be the death of him. The sound he let out was strangled, a choked whimper.

"Does it hurt?" Phainon asked, knowing full well that Mydei's injuries had stopped aching a long time ago. His caresses took a steady rhythm.

“No.” Mydei squirmed under the touch.

He wanted it to stop and he needed Phainon to continue. It was too much, but it would also never be enough. It was more than they had ever allowed themselves to have, and it was already too overwhelming.

He did not know what had urged Phainon to cross that flimsy line they had tacitly agreed on. They usually liked to act as if it was an impenetrable rampart; never going too far with their touches, never saying too much of their feelings for the other. But it was not. And, unfortunately, Mydei’s body was as honest as he was.

“No, and that’s the problem.” He breathed.

Phainon stopped hiding his face away. Digging his chin in Mydei’s soft breast, he stared right into the blond’s eyes.

“Why is it a problem, Mydeimos?” He asked, frustration slipping through his tone.

Mydei let the silence stretch between them.

Phainon’s brows furrowed and his grip on Mydei’s waist strengthened. His stroking ceased as his other hand dropped to the mattress loudly, and Mydei refrained himself from grabbing it, already missing the touch.

“Is it because that’s not a blade grazing your skin? Is it because this is something tender, different, and not just punches?” His voice started off sharp, pent up feelings hidden underneath, but then, it broke down. “Do you actually enjoy pain?”

Mydei’s breath hitched. Pined under the weight of Phainon’s gaze, he felt uncovered, naked.

“I don’t *enjoy* pain.” He growled.

How he loathed, but how he loved, the attention Phainon was always giving him. He hated how he wanted to indulge in it. He wanted the luxury of being careful with his life, to soothe Phainon’s worries, to return to him unscathed without fail.

He craved Phainon’s care, aware that such a life was unbefitting for a warrior like him, warriors like them. The contradiction between his responsibilities and his desires was testing his restraint everyday, paining him as much as it pleasured him to imagine himself relishing in them.

Mydei gritted his teeth before speaking up again, “I tolerate it. I tolerate it better than everyone, Deliverer.”

Phainon’s lips tightened. “And I know you do. But,” He put some distance between them, facing Mydei properly “you never allow your body to rest. You forbid yourself so many things. You only ever accept *this*,” His hand trailed up along Mydei’s thigh, making the blond shiver once again, “if it has the intent of hurting you.”

“Like *you’re* any better.” Mydei almost snarled at him.

The shift was immediate. He felt Phainon's body tensing against him, his hand curling into a tight fist, pressing into the meat of Mydei's thigh. Phainon knitted his eyebrows, and something dark obscured his face and passed through his eyes before he scolded his features back to neutrality.

"This isn't about me." His tone was detached, eyes avoidant. Distant.

"I'm making it about you." Mydei replied firmly.

He studied the white haired man's face - the frail facade of this man - before sighing and grabbing it with both hands, forcing eye contact.

"If you want to address my lack of selfcare, let's address yours too."

Phainon's eyes visibly widened, obviously not expecting the situation to bite back at him.

Mydei had wanted to laugh at that; it was ridiculous how selfless the deliverer was. A bottomless pit of love and hatred, a man that was fueled by revenge, but also by the expectations of others. A desire to be something for someone, for the world, too strong at times to be healthy. And Mydei knew it all too well how it felt to feed off resentment, to lose everything.

Perhaps, this is why they had become kindred spirits. But Mydei also knew how vengeance never fully healed a man; it only filled the hollow in your heart temporarily with material slowly decaying - rotting - the filth extending to all your thorax, leaving behind an empty shell.

Mydei brought Phainon closer, the tip of his nose brushing against Phainon's.

"You think no one will notice your pain if you just keep that stupid grin on your face, but we do. I do."

Phainon's pupils shook subtly. Up close, Mydei could count the yellow spikes of his irises and see the vulnerability, the sorrow, that he failed to hide. Mydei's features softened at the sight, the tension in his body completely erased by his affection towards that man.

"You're not the only one who cares. I also wish you would treat yourself kinder, Phainon." He whispered earnestly, echoing the words back to him.

He felt Phainon's warm breath tickle his lips as Phainon's mouth opened slightly, speechless. Mydei's thumbs started to stroke tenderly his cheeks, tracing the contour of his cheekbones, and Phainon trembled. Mydei reveled in the way the man was reacting to his touch, how he was able to render him breathless just as much as Phainon could make him.

Perhaps, it was because he wanted to prove Phainon wrong, that he could accept *this* - as Phainon had called it -, the natural urge of being defiant resurfacing. Or, maybe, it was simply because Phainon had dismantled the last of his barriers. But Mydei closed the remaining distance between them, pressing a gentle kiss on Phainon's lips, his eyes shutting down.

Seconds passed before Mydei felt lips moving against his, a second hand resting on the other side of his waist, like it had always belonged there. The kiss was slow, tender, their lips moving in tandem and their breath loud and moist.

Mydei wanted to press their bodies even more, to share their warmth. Frustrated that their legs were in the way, he slightly raised himself on his knee and used one hand to come closer, their lips never parting. The side of his calf slid against Phainon's thigh on the bed and Mydei slotted himself there, trapping the deliverer between his legs.

He hovered over Phainon, refusing to sit down yet, and the new angle allowed him to deepen the kiss. Phainon's hands explored his body anew, encircling his waist, stroking his spine, and a sob escaped his lips. Mydei drank the sound, breathed in Phainon's scent, and lost himself to his touch, his embrace. He only emerged when he felt a sort of wetness at his fingertips.

"Deliverer," The blond pulled back, panting, and Phainon stared up at him, his eyes shining and darkened, akin to sapphires, "A - are you … crying?" He wiped away the tears that trickled down his cheeks.

Phainon remained silent but leaned into the touch. He took Mydei's wrists and pressed an hesitant kiss on his palm, before pressing another, and another. Mydei could only watch as Phainon peppered his hand with soft kisses, his ears growing red. His stomach twisted with want, so much want, and love.

He realised that tasting Phainon one time was not enough, it would never be enough; he needed to taste him on his tongue again, and again, and he needed Phainon to devour him, to pleasure him so ardently that it would start to hurt. He wanted to return that feeling tenfold and leave bruises near that sun-shaped tattoo etched on his neck.

But Phainon's devotion seemed to take another form, more gentle, as he started to rumble against Mydei's palm, "I want to show you what tenderness is, what gentleness is. I want to soothe every wound of yours, I want to make your body feel used to pleasure rather than pain. I want to make love to you. I want too much and I don't know if I deserve it, if I even can -"

Mydei kissed the corner of his mouth to cut him off. "Just take. Want. Allow yourself to." He kissed him again, "And if you don't allow yourself to take me, I will still give myself to you."

He heard Phainon's breath stopped for a second and he watched something burn anew in his eyes as Phainon registered what this meant, his grip on Mydei's waist tightening.

"Do you understand the weight of your words?" Phainon asked him, his voice low and shaky.

Mydei stared back at him, thumb stroking unruly, slightly wet from tears, hair strands away from Phainon's temple. Depending on his answer, there would be no turning back.

He had been deprived of affection and had fled it, taking refuge in violence. Now, he found out that he loved the thrill of being in Phainon's arms as much as he loved the thrill of battle. Maybe, he would even learn to love it more.

The fear of letting himself be vulnerable continued to gnaw at him, a constant reminder at the back of his mind that the flame-chase journey had not ended, that they were still not safe from losing each other. They had already lost so much yet, even silently, even when they did not admit it, did not act on it, they had yearned for this. And he - more than ever - wished for the deliverer to be selfish for once, wished for the both of them to finally let go of everything, even for a moment in the confines of that blue bedroom.

Mydei pressed his forehead against Phainon's and replied, "I do." It sounded like a vow.

Phainon pulled him down instantly, forcing Mydei to sit down on his thighs with so much strength that their teeth clanked as their mouths crashed together anew, devouring each other until their moans were the only sounds filling the air.

Bare chest pressed against Phainon's clothed one, Mydei started with a tentative roll of his hips, drinking the whimper that escaped Phainon's lips, followed by another roll, and another. He grinded against the growing tent in Phainon's trousers, their heartbeats, synched, fast, and loud, setting the rhythm of his movements.

The friction left the both of them breathless, mindless, arousal clouding their heads as they drowned in each other's warmth and embrace. The kisses were wet, open, messy - and maybe even a little bit inexperienced - but they relished in the pleasure, the heat, finally savouring the taste of the other.

"Mydei," Phainon panted against his mouth, "Mydei. Please."

He stared at the blond with glazy eyes, pupils blown out, and he begged, "P - please. Just promise."

Mydei's hands went up to Phainon's hair, tugging on the strands at his nape to tilt the man's head and to continue to kiss him deeply. His lips never left Phainon's as if he feared he would forget what they felt like if they parted for even one second.

Phainon tasted just like how he smelled; sweet, divine and unfairly intoxicating.

Mydei licked into his mouth, devouring every corner of it which was accessible to him. Phainon trembled beneath him, his hands gripping at Mydei's waist and imprinting faint traces on it, and Mydei felt the man's trousers dampening, his own also beginning to stick to his skin. They both shivered, already too close to climax, and Phainon tried to speak between two moans.

"Please." Phainon whined once more, insistent. "Please, Mydeimos."

Mydei let out a low groan, reluctant to part, but he obeyed. He stilled his hips, already mourning the loss of friction, and pressed a chaste kiss on Phainon's eyelid.

He took a moment to observe Phainon, marvelling at how beautiful he looked; disheveled hair with red and abused lips, and dark blue eyes filled with lust. His hands continued to stroke the man's nape and he gulped before replying, at last.

“I can’t promise you that my body will never shatter again. My soul will wander Styxia over and over again, crossing that river and confronting past phantoms I thought I would never see again. But I promise,” his breathing was heavy, and his voice raspy, but more sincere than ever, as he said, “I promise to come back to you every time and let your caresses heal me.”

Phainon smiled a small but genuine thing, tears gathering at the corner of his eyes. He took Mydei’s mouth and the kiss was even more hungry, hurried, their patience running thin. He thrusted in the air one time to encourage Mydei to move again, and, soon, they moved in unison, chasing their pleasure shamelessly.

Eyes closed, Mydei could only hear the filthy noise of their tongues tangling and their ragged breath as he felt a knot tighten in his lower abdomen, a hot and burning sensation growing fast.

One of Phainon’s hands went up to cup his breast, squeezing the soft muscle, thumb grazing and teasing the pink bud there, and Mydei’s whole body visibly shook. He clenched on white hair strands, eliciting a loud whimper from the man beneath him, and he felt a warmth spread between his thighs, staining the borrowed clothes.

Mydei stilled and slumped against Phainon, singing moans against his neck, and Phainon’s thrusts grew weaker until he reached his climax too, body trembling. They were both panting and sweaty - sticky - but they stayed huddled together, heartbeats resonating in each other’s chest.

Phainon’s hands naturally resumed their stroking on Mydei’s hips and back, soothing him, as the tension in his stomach settled down. Mydei finally let go of Phainon’s hair, and encircled his neck with his arms in a tight embrace.

The atmosphere in the bedroom was intimate, a comfortable silence that allowed them to catch their breath. Phainon was the first to break it.

“Can we really have this?” He whispered in Mydei’s ear, his voice hoarse and too attractive for Mydei’s sanity.

“Hmpf.” Mydei huffed, blowing air on Phainon’s neck, making the deliverer shiver, “So now, you’re having doubts. Who was the one who put his hands on me first?”

He did not give Phainon time to respond and peppered the side of his neck with wet kisses, right above the sun mark, nibbling at it with sharp teeth.

Phainon’s head tilted back, exposing more of that sweaty skin, and Mydei tasted it with the tip of his tongue, lapping at it. The man beneath him moaned - a tent already stretching his trousers again - and Mydei took that as a sign to let one of his hands wander past Phainon’s collarbones, sliding against the fabric hiding hardened muscles and abs. He fumbled blindly with the belt but Phainon’s hand caught his wrist, stopping him.

“Y- You’re injured, Mydei.” He managed to breathe, clearly wanting more too. “Let’s stop here for today -”

Mydei freed his hand to in turn grab Phainon's wrist, guiding it until Phainon's palm rested on the expanse of his stomach, muscles twitching at the contact.

"I'm not." He moved Phainon's hand around for him to feel the healed and pristine skin below, "See, nothing."

Phainon gulped, reason and lust clashing in those glazy eyes of his. He stared at the tan skin there, licking his lips a few times, before redirecting his gaze back at Mydei's face.

"Still, I don't think this is a good idea. You should rest, we can do this next time."

Mydei raised an eyebrow and asked, "Next time? Does that mean I have to get injured for this to happen again?"

Phainon's frown was immediate.

Mydei chuckled and let go of Phainon's wrist to soothe the crease between his eyebrows with his fingertips. "Relax. That was in jest."

Phainon's features relaxed and he sighed, his hand coming to hold Mydei's hip, rubbing circles around the projecting part of it.

"Don't ever leave me, Mydei." He pronounced those words like they were a command, but Mydei could clearly perceive the fragility and vulnerability hidden underneath.

The immortal gazed back at him and something in his stomach twisted. This was another promise which Mydei could not make. The love that they shared was a liability during the flame-chase journey; they were already defying fate enough by embracing each other here and now.

"I will be here as long as you will have me." *And for as long as I can*, he did not say outloud.

Phainon seemed to understand what he truly meant but did not push further this time. He continued to draw soothing circles on Mydei's skin.

Mydei planted a quick kiss on his lips. "So, next time. Alright."

He shifted on Phainon's laps to rest his weight further away from the man's crotch.

"Rest does sound nice. Right now, you look exhausted. Was this already too much for you? Where's your stamina, Deliverer?" He taunted him.

Phainon bit at the bait, "I'll show you what too much is."

He then smirked and it took all of Mydei's restraint to not chase back those inviting lips of his and abuse them even more. As if he could sense it, Phainon lifted him up easily, laying Mydei down gently on his back on the bed, and placed a pillow behind his head.

Straddling Mydei's waist, one hand beside the blond's head as support, Phainon stroked a fiery red strand of hair away from his face and his eyes shone with so much adoration as he

repeated, “Next time, that is.”

They could only pray that there would never be a last time.

End Notes

im free !!!!! i can finally work on pregdei week now

you can find me on twt and bluesky @ vaendeimos

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